

How to Find an Arthritis Buddy for Peer Support

Practical NHS-backed advice on how to find an arthritis buddy for peer support.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: Arthritis peer support buddies are available through the NRAS Volunteer Ambassador programme, Versus Arthritis self-help groups, Arthritis Action, and online communities including Healthunlocked. These connect you with someone who has lived experience of arthritis for practical advice and emotional support.

Research consistently shows that peer support improves pain management, reduces depression, and increases confidence in managing long-term conditions.

NRAS Volunteer Ambassador Programme

The National Rheumatoid Arthritis Society (NRAS) runs a volunteer ambassador programme where trained volunteers with lived RA experience provide one-to-one support. This is particularly valuable around the time of diagnosis. Contact NRAS on 0800 298 7650 to be connected with an ambassador.

Online Peer Communities



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Best Online Arthritis Peer Support Communities

- NRAS Healthunlocked: nras.healthunlocked.com — active RA community with thousands of UK members
- Versus Arthritis online community: community.versusarthritis.org
- Living With Arthritis community: livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Q&A;

Question: Can I become a peer support volunteer myself? **Short answer:** Yes — both Versus Arthritis and NRAS actively recruit volunteers with arthritis experience. Being a buddy benefits both the person supported and the volunteer.

Question: Is peer support only for people recently diagnosed? **Short answer:** Not at all — peer support is valuable at any stage, including when navigating medication changes, employment challenges, or mental health difficulties.

Question: Are online communities safe and moderated? **Short answer:** The NRAS Healthunlocked and Versus Arthritis communities are both moderated by trained staff. Always verify medical advice with your healthcare team before acting on it.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk